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Original Page: 68**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1958-1964**Coverage Date:** Ca. 1958-1964**Place Coverage:** G/Wi San, Botswana**Section Title(S)**(1) Membership — Recruitment of Members and Formation of New Bands. • (5) The Effects of the System. • THE BAND

It is a feature of many cultures that a specially friendly or affectionate relationship exists between alternate generations. Among the G/wi, where these are joking partners, this serves the useful purpose of allowing the grandparents to act as a counterweight to the perhaps somewhat austere authority of the parents and also to explain the parents' point of view to the children on a more friendly basis. Here, as elsewhere, it is far easier to be reasonable and objective about something when one has not the responsibility of being in charge, and it is also easier to accept the explanation of somebody other than the person who gave the order in the first place.

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Of one's closer kin, those who are in the avoidance category are either siblings of the opposite sex, or parents (real, foster, or in-laws) to whose authority one is subject. The reserved, respectful behaviour of the avoidance relationship is appropriate between brother and sister and avoids any temptation to, or suggestion of, incest. Between parent and child this behaviour greatly lessens the likelihood of rebellion or disobedience. As far as more distant kin are concerned, although there is no danger of incest and the exercise of authority is not present in the relationships, the classification of some as avoidance kin is explicable in terms of the principle of alternate generations, i.e. if one jokes with another, then his parents and children (to proximate generations) are automatically in the avoidance category and a possible clash of attitude is avoided because one then has the same joking/avoidance attitude to his next of kin as he has, as has been explained above.

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THE BAND

(1) *Membership – Recruitment of Members and Formation of New Bands.*

The band consists, as has been suggested above, of some fifty or so members in most instances. Membership is permanent in the sense that it is never lost, as far as I can ascertain, but this does not mean that it is unchanging, because individuals and families may leave their old band and join up with another, where they will then be accepted as full members with the same rights as have all the others. Despite this they may return to their old band whenever they wish. One's band membership is therefore not exclusive. As strife between bands is avoided by the G/wi, there is no question of conflicting loyalties to one or another band and membership only entails the enjoyment of certain rights, not the fulfilment of obligations, so simultaneous membership of more than one band never imposes on a man a choice of allegiances. The only questions are whether the man wants to join the band, and whether the band wants him.

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A man may acquire membership of a new band by establishing his inherited rights, i.e. that his parents or grandparents or, rarely, even more remote ancestors were members. This almost inevitably means that he has relatives who are already members and that he would merely take his place in the kinship group which therefore has a territorial and, hence, economic significance. He may also marry into the band but in order to do this he must first be generally approved. Marriages are not only the affair of the couple themselves, but of the whole band, who will first fully discuss the suitability of the intended spouses for one another⁶⁹ and as members of the community, before adding the weight of their opinion to the deliberation of the parents of the girl. Even if it causes her a certain amount of sorrow, a girl will accept her parents' rejection of a suitor as being the right thing. If the suitor persists and is crass enough not to take the hint (which ill-bred behaviour proves to everybody that he was the wrong man, anyway) he is chased away by the parents. If his suit is successful, then he is integrated into the girl's kinship group as an in-law. Thirdly, membership may be applied for simply by arriving on the scene and asking to be allowed to stay on. It is most unusual for anybody to go to an unknown band, and moves are usually made to people who have often been visited before and are well-known, and where the applicant himself is well-known. There are good reasons why these moves are made; perhaps the applicant has a brother who married into the band and he wants to be with him, or he has other kin there. Sometimes the parent band has grown too large and is in process of splitting. Another cause is the fact that bands have marked group personalities: one may consist of people who are by habit quiet and serious, another may be a gay crowd or perhaps people who enjoy a bit of a bite in their humour. Among fifty people, there are bound to be a few individuals who are not at home in this or that atmosphere, but find the company of another band more congenial to their natures. Very rarely is there the misfit who is not really at home anywhere and, like a van der Decken of the Kalahari, wanders round the desert all his life, trying one band after another. Such persons are dealt with in a typically gentle fashion by the G/wi, who ease them out, not by making it apparent that they are unpopular, but by the band making themselves unpopular to the unwanted member by behaving stupidly and never quite grasping his meaning when he says anything. This form of passive resistance, which is carried out with every appearance of goodwill, is quite effective enough and avoids any lasting

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feeling of resentment on the part of the parting guest, who leaves very much more in sorrow than in anger, and avoids aggressive urges in the band itself.

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